

THE THREE BEARS.



PICTURED
BY
A.E. Kennedy.



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THE THREE BEARS.

There was once a happy little family of Bears—Papa, Mamma and Johnny Bear—living in a cozy cottage near a large forest.



One day, when the sun was shining and the woods looked so bright and beautiful, Papa Bear said to his family, “I think we ought to go for a long walk and enjoy the sunshine.”

“Yes,” answered Mamma Bear, “that will be very nice and jolly; but before we go, I must get our luncheon ready.”

So they waited until Mamma Bear had cooked three bowls of hot porridge—there was a great big bowlful for Papa Bear, a middle-sized one for herself, and a tiny little one for Johnny. When she was finished and had put

the three bowls on the table to cool, Papa Bear took out his big, silver-handled cane, and they started off for a long walk. On the way, little Johnny had lots of fun playing with his kite.



Getting ready for the walk.



They found a lovely, shady spot in the middle of the woods, and here they sat down. Little Johnny climbed a big branch, Mamma Bear sat with her back against the tree, while Papa Bear was so tired that all he could do was to sit on the ground, and very soon he fell fast asleep.

Then Johnny Bear came down the tree, and ran around, picking lots of gay, pretty flowers in the fields and chasing all the bright butterflies that flew around him. By and by, he saw that his Mamma had dropped her knitting and was also fast asleep; so there was nothing left for little Johnny but to lie down in the shade and shut his eyes, and soon he, too, was in dreamland. There was the whole Bear family tight asleep in the woods!

Now, that very morning, a little girl had lost her way. This little girl's name was Goldenlocks, because her hair was so bright and yellow that it seemed like real gold. Poor little Goldenlocks had started out for a walk, but had lost the path that led back to her house. So she wandered about in the woods, frightened and very hungry, until she spied the house which belonged to the Three Bears. Of course, she did not know that the Bears lived in it, and so she was not afraid to go up to the door and knock.



In the woods.

Nobody answered, and since she was so hungry, she dared to peep through. What do you think she saw? Why! right on a table in front of her stood the three bowls of steaming porridge that Mamma Bear had set out to cool! Goldenlock's mouth watered at the sight of these tempting bowls, and, though she knew it was wrong, she jumped into the dining-room.

Goldenlocks began by trying the porridge in the biggest bowl. She dipped a large spoon into the food, but the porridge was so hot that it almost burned her tongue off.

Next she tried the middle-sized bowl; but she did not like this any better, for the porridge was not sweet enough.

Last of all, she tried the smallest bowl—and this was fine! It was just right, and Goldenlocks soon ate every bit of it.

When she had finished all the porridge in the smallest bowl, she still felt very tired. In one corner of the room, she saw three chairs in a row—a big one, a middle-sized one, and a little one. At first, Goldenlocks thought she would like the biggest chair best of all, and so she climbed up on it; but the seat was too broad and the back too high, and she was not comfortable.

Next she tried the middle-sized chair; but that was too hard, and she did not like it, either.

Last she tried the smallest chair, and this, again, was just right! She felt so comfortable that she sat in it a long, long time—until the bottom gave way and she tumbled to the floor!

Goldenlocks then looked around for a bed, so that she could lie down and sleep. She went upstairs on her tip-toes, and there she found three beds. And these beds, just like the bowls and chairs, were, first, a big one, which belonged to Papa Bear; then a middle-sized one, which was Mamma Bear's, and last of all, a little one for Johnny Bear.

Goldenlocks tried them all, but could not make herself comfortable except in the smallest bed. So she lay down on that, and as quick as a wink, was fast asleep.

Now, the Bear family all woke up, out in the woods, and looked at one another in surprise. "My heavens!" said Mamma Bear, "here it is almost dinner-time, and we are far from home."

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“Who’s been eating my porridge?”

But just think what they saw when they entered the dining room! “Who’s been tasting my porridge?” grumbled Papa Bear, in his deep, angry voice.

“Who’s been tasting my porridge?” cried Mamma Bear, all excited.

“Who’s been tasting my porridge and eaten it all up?” squealed little Johnny Bear, at the top of his shrill voice.

Then Papa Bear spied the three chairs in the corner. “Who’s been sitting in my chair?” he roared.

“Who’s been sitting in my chair?” cried Mamma Bear.

“Who’s been sitting in my chair and broken it all to pieces?” screamed Johnny Bear, and he began to cry bitterly.

They were all very angry and upset. They hunted all over the house for the stranger who had spoilt their dinner and broken Johnny’s chair. They could find no one downstairs, so they went up to their bedroom.

Here Papa Bear thundered out another terrible roar—“Who’s been lying on my bed?” Mamma Bear looked at her bed, and then she, too, exclaimed, “Who’s been lying on my bed and mussed it all up?” Little Johnny Bear rushed up to his own bed, and cried, “Who’s been lying on my bed—oh, look! there she is!”





At once , there were awful noises and excitement. Poor Goldilocks jumped out of bed and ran downstairs as fast as she could. Papa and Mama Bear



and Little Johnny followed her, growling and threatening her, until she was frightened out of her wits. She saw an open window and through this she

jumped and made her escape. She was soon far away, through the woods and back home. She promised her mother that she would never again wander away.



Goldenlocks' escape.

Transcriber's note

Some illustrations were moved from where they were in the original to place them nearer to the text describing the picture.

Minor punctuation errors have been changed without notice.

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